

Personal Brand: Between Meaning and Market

At first glance, a delicate bracelet and a Stanley Cup might seem like ordinary items in a college student's life, but each tells a deeper story. This paper emerges from an anthropological research project at UNC that asked: how do students construct their personal brands? Through seventy-two interviews, students shared how they navigate self-expression in a world shaped by fast-moving trends, social media, and deep personal attachments. While "brand" is often associated with fashion or corporate logos, students described it in more nuanced ways: as a reflection of who they are, what they value, and how they cope with social expectations. A personal brand can signal individuality, but also fit into broader social trends, revealing a tension between authenticity and conformity. A student's personal brand, I argue, is shaped by two intertwined forces: personal meaning—rooted in relationships, memories, and affections—and social expectation—driven by online trends, corporate influence, and peer emulation. To explain this, I'll use Marcel Mauss's theory of the gift, Naomi Klein's theory of branding, and Georg Simmel's concepts of fashion and emulation. Together, these frameworks reveal how students craft identity by balancing individuality and conformity through both gifted and commodified objects.

For many students, the most meaningful parts of their personal brand are not defined by trendy purchases or fashionable logos, but by personal gifts—especially those given by people they care about. Marcel Mauss's classic theory in *The Gift: The Form and Reason for Exchange in Archaic Societies* provides a powerful lens to understand this phenomenon. For Mauss, gifts are never merely material objects; instead, they embody social relationships and moral obligations. As Mauss writes, "to make a gift of something to someone is to make a present of some part of oneself," the gifts carry with them what he calls *Hau*—a piece of the giver's soul,

emotions, or intentions (Mauss, 12). The *Hau* continues to affect the recipient even after the gift is given, sustaining a living tie across time and space. In this sense, gifts are never free; they forge spiritual and social bonds, and they seek reciprocity—not necessarily in the form of a return object, but in continued relational acknowledgment.

Curious about how these ideas might play out in the context of college students' self-branding, I analyzed 72 interview write-ups. While the term “gift” appeared only once in the freelist data, meaningful gifted items surfaced repeatedly in the narratives. I conducted a keyword search for “gift,” “gifted,” “give,” “gave,” and “given,” identifying 16 responses that described personally significant items received from others. These gifts included marble chess sets, scarves, flowers, and more—but jewelry stood out, accounting for half of the cases (8 out of 16). Jewelry was not only the most frequently mentioned gift, but also the most symbolically rich, often described as emotionally, culturally, and spiritually significant. To explore how gifts contribute to students' personal brands, I focus here on jewelry as a representative case.

Gifted jewelry helps students build a personal brand rooted in family traditions and cultural identity. For example, ZRL2 treasures a collection of Indian-style gold jewelry that her grandfather gifts her whenever she returns to India: “Whenever I visit back India, my grandpa will take me out and buy me jewelry as a tradition” (ZRL2). This jewelry ties her identity to her family and her cultural background. She also explained that “the Indian earrings set me apart because I can only find them there” (ZRL2), showing how her brand includes uniqueness based on cultural pride. Her grandfather's love and tradition become part of how she sees herself and presents herself to others. She is not only an individual but also a granddaughter who honors her family's heritage.

Other students wear jewelry to stay connected with loved ones who are far away. VEG1 wears a matching evil-eye anklet gifted by her mother: “It helps me bond with my mom even though she’s super far away from me” (VEG1). Even though she described most of her clothing as “super basic,” this anklet stood out because it represented emotional support and protection. By wearing it, she reinforces her personal brand as someone who values family ties and carries her mother’s care with her.

Religious and life milestones are also key parts of students’ identities, and gifted jewelry helps mark these important moments. GHM1 received a ring for her confirmation and a cross necklace for her graduation from her grandmother. “I hold a lot of sentimental value in jewelry,” she said, because these gifts represent both her religious faith and her family’s support at important stages of her life (GHM1). Her brand includes her Catholic upbringing and the moral values passed down by her family.

Jewelry can also keep alive memories of people who have passed away. HMC2 described receiving a necklace that once belonged to her late grandmother: “When my dad gave me an old piece of jewelry that belonged to my grandmother... I really identify with this because me and her used to be very close and I adored her” (HMC2). The necklace is more than a keepsake; it is a physical reminder of love and personal history. JM1 shared a similar experience: her collection of necklaces and bracelets—many of them gifts—each has a “story or memory attached to it” (JM1). These pieces reflect her culture and religion, important parts of her identity.

Through these examples, we see how personal brands are shaped by the emotional and social meanings embedded in gifts. Jewelry carries the giver’s hopes, love, and values. When students wear these items, they are not simply remembering someone—they are internalizing traits tied to the giver. A grandmother’s faith, a mother’s care, a grandfather’s pride, or a friend’s

support becomes part of how students define and express themselves. Receiving a gift quietly encourages them to grow into the qualities the giver valued—faithfulness, strength, pride, care, and cultural connection. These gifts also bridge long distances and life stages: among the 16 responses I identified, only 1 student is from Chapel Hill, with 4 from in-state, 7 out-of-state, and 3 international. For students far from home, gifts carry love and belonging into new environments. VEG1’s anklet serves as daily emotional armor and a reminder of her mother. GHM1’s jewelry, layered with religious meaning, reflects a shared family identity. ZRL2’s Indian earrings, worn in an American context, reaffirm her cultural background. In Mauss’s terms, these gifts remain active—they bind, remind, and shape the recipients.

Mauss also emphasizes reciprocity, arguing that gifts must be returned in order to complete the social contract. In his view, the *Hau* of the gift seeks to return to its source; to ignore this pull risks spiritual imbalance or moral debt. Interestingly, none of the students I interviewed explicitly mentioned reciprocating the gifts they received. At first glance, this appears to challenge Mauss’s theory. But on closer examination, the idea of reciprocity may still hold—just in less visible forms. In these cases, students practice what I will call “emotional reciprocity”—rather than giving a physical object in return, students often reciprocate through love, values, and sustained emotional connections. ZRL2 repays her grandfather not with gold, but with loyalty to her heritage and pride in her cultural difference. GHM1 honors her grandmother’s religious intentions by remaining committed to her faith. These forms of intangible reciprocity are just as powerful, binding the student to the giver across generations and geographies. In this sense, the interviews not only support Mauss’s theory, but extend it—showing how reciprocity can be emotional, symbolic, or spiritual.

Ultimately, when students include gifted jewelry in their personal brands, they are not just displaying style—they are displaying relationships. In a branding culture that often encourages conformity, gifts offer a way to be different by staying true to where you come from and who you love. The gift, as Mauss suggested, is not just a thing—it’s a soul in transit. For these students, it’s a soul they choose to wear—on their necks, wrists, and ears—for the world to see.

While gifted objects helped students build personal brands based on real relationships and memories, commodified goods show how branding and social trends pressure students to shape their identities for conformity. Naomi Klein argues that modern brands sell not just products, but lifestyles and emotional connections: “Brands are not simply advertising; they are about creating a meaning system for our lives” (Klein, 21). Georg Simmel similarly explains that fashion allows people to fit into a group while trying to keep some personal distinction: “Fashion satisfies the need for social adaptation; it leads the individual on the road to social acceptance” (Simmel, 542). Together, Klein and Simmel help explain how students use branded objects to balance fitting in with standing out, reflecting the core tension between authenticity and conformity introduced at the beginning of this paper.

This section will take water bottles as a representative case study since water bottles were one of the most common items associated with personal brands, mentioned 21 times out of 72 interviews. Of those who mentioned water bottles, over 90% specifically named brands like Stanley or Owala. This shows how much brand identity shapes even everyday objects—students were not just talking about “a water bottle,” but about what owning a certain brand says about them. Students’ interviews around commodified water bottles fall into three main patterns:

following trends for social belonging, customizing trends to feel unique, and thinking critically about consumer culture.

First, many students emphasized how commodified goods allow them to fit into broader social trends. AB1 described her Stanley cup as a way to signal health consciousness, environmental values, and trend awareness: “It shows you're into health and hydration but also that you care about the environment because it's reusable. Plus, it's a bit of a trend—everyone seems to have one in class or at the gym” (AB1). This example fits Simmel’s idea that fashion provides a way for individuals to align themselves with social groups while maintaining relevance. Similarly, SRG2 emphasized how seeing Stanley tumblers on TikTok and around campus helped her realize that “everyday things can be part of a personal aesthetic and even spark conversations with strangers” (SRG2). Here, branding provides a shared language of belonging, echoing Klein’s view that brands create emotional meaning systems that connect consumers.

Second, some students talked about how they adapted commodified objects to express personal individuality. SLF2 highlighted how her Stanley water bottle became a personalized accessory: “I can personalize with stickers, making it a little more me” (SLF2). This personalization reflects Simmel’s point that fashion allows for differentiation even within conformity, as individuals modify standardized items to showcase unique identities. Similarly, AK1 described her Owala bottle: “I carry her literally everywhere... I also like the color [purple], it kinda gives ‘me’” (AK1), showing how even a mass-produced product can become a symbol of personal style. These examples suggest that while students adopt trends, they still seek small ways to assert authenticity within the pressures of mass branding.

Third, some students showed clear awareness of the pressures and contradictions involved in branded consumption. SA2 described how Stanley Cups have become symbols of social conformity: “I feel like people who buy this kind of stuff are kind of like sheep” (SA2). Her language—“like sheep”—directly reflects Simmel’s concept of fashion as a social force that demands conformity. For Simmel, individuals often adopt trends not out of deep desire but because they fear social exclusion. SA2’s resistance shows that even while recognizing the social power of trends, some students push back against them in order to reclaim authenticity. CLB2 echoed this unease, saying, “I bought a Stanley Cup when they started trending about two years ago. I don't know why I bought it because I already had a water bottle that worked perfectly fine” (CLB2). Her admission that the product was unnecessary reveals the influence of emotional branding, as described by Klein. Rather than solving a problem, the Stanley Cup created a new desire tied to visibility and participation in trend culture. Klein’s theory explains how corporations like Stanley embed identity and aspiration into products, so that consumers feel that not buying them means missing out on a shared lifestyle.

In the end, students’ personal brands are shaped by a constant push and pull between expressing who they truly are and fitting into what others expect. Gifted items like jewelry carry emotional weight—they connect students to family, culture, and memories, offering a form of authenticity that feels grounded and personal. In contrast, commodified goods like Stanley Cups and Owala bottles reflect the pressures of modern branding culture, where identity is performed through objects tied to trends and corporate influence. Students aren’t passively buying into trends, but they’re also not fully outside them. Even those who question branding still find themselves affected by it. Personal branding, then, becomes less a fixed statement and more a daily dynamic negotiation—between the authentic self and the social mirror.

Works Cited

Interview Responses (conducted at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, Spring 2025):

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